



Glossary: Glossary Title

Estimated Time: 15 minutes

Welcomel This alphabetized glossary contains many terms used in this course.

Term	Definition
5 whys	A problem-solving method that identifies root causes by repeatedly asking "why" until the underlying cause is revealed.
Activity	A task or action in a process, typically shown as a rectangle or rounded rectangle.
Activity-based costing (ABC)	A costing method that allocates overhead and indirect costs to products or services based on the activities that drive those costs.
Actor	A user or external system that interacts with a process or system within a use case.
AI-assisted analysis	Leveraging generative AI tools to support problem definition, cause identification, and solution development in process improvement.
AI Prompt	A clear, structured instruction given to an AI system to guide output quality and ensure relevance to the user's goal.
AI-assisted visualization	The use of AI tools such as Lucidchart AI, Gemini, and Claude to automatically create process maps, SIPOCs, or workflow diagrams from text inputs.
Automation tool	Software such as UiPath, Zapier, or Monday.com that executes automated workflows across business systems.
Balanced scorecard	A strategic planning tool that links business activities to organizational goals through four perspectives: financial, customer, internal processes, and learning/growth.
Brainstorming	A creative group or individual technique used to generate a wide range of ideas or solutions during analysis or problem-solving sessions.
Business analyst (BA)	A professional responsible for identifying business needs, analyzing processes, and recommending solutions that deliver value to stakeholders.
Business process	A collection of related tasks or activities that produce a specific outcome or service for customers or stakeholders.
Business Process Model and Notation (BPMN)	A standardized visual language used to model complex business processes with symbols representing events, activities, gateways, and flows.
Change implementation guide	A structured outline for planning, communicating, and executing change initiatives while minimizing resistance.
Change readiness checklist	A tool to evaluate whether the organization, teams, and systems are prepared for change implementation.
Connector	A symbol used in process mapping to show continuity between parts of a process, either on the same page or across multiple pages.
Continuous improvement (Kaizen)	The ongoing pursuit of incremental process enhancements aimed at improving efficiency, quality, and customer satisfaction.
Control chart	A graphical SPC tool that tracks process variation and identifies when performance is outside expected limits.
Control plan	A document outlining how improvements will be monitored, who is responsible, and what actions to take if performance declines.
Cost driver	A measurable factor that directly causes or influences the cost of an activity, such as machine hours or the number of orders.
Cross-functional process	A workflow that spans multiple departments or roles, requiring clear coordination and visibility.
Current state map	The VSM showing how a process operates today, including all steps, wait times, and inefficiencies.
Current state process	A model that represents how a process currently operates, including existing steps, roles, and pain points.
Customer	The internal or external recipient of the outputs.
Cycle time (CT)	The total time required to complete one process activity from start to finish.
Data flow diagram (DFD)	A diagram that shows how data moves through a process or system, including inputs, outputs, and storage points.
Decision (diamond)	A symbol in a process map that represents a point where a choice must be made, often leading to different paths.
Decomposition	Breaking a large process or function into smaller, more manageable subprocesses or activities.
DMAIC	A Six Sigma problem-solving framework: Define, Measure, Analyze, Improve, Control.
Document symbol	A shape in process mapping that represents a physical or digital document used or produced in a process.
Eight wastes (DOWNTIME)	The key types of waste in Lean: Defects, Overproduction, Waiting, Non-utilized talent, Transportation, Inventory, Motion, and Extra processing.
End event	A BPMN symbol indicating where a process concludes.
Entity relationship diagram (ERD)	A data modeling technique that visually represents the relationships between key data entities such as customers, products, or orders.
Event-based gateway	A gateway where the next path is determined by an event rather than a decision.
Exception path	An alternate flow taken when a condition is not met such as "payment rejected."
Exclusive gateway (XOR)	A decision point where only one path is taken based on a condition.
Fishbone (Ishikawa) diagram	A visual root-cause tool categorizing potential causes under headings such as People, Process, Technology, and Management.
Flow	The smooth, continuous movement of materials, information, or work through a process without interruptions or delays.
Flowchart	A standardized type of process map using symbols such as rectangles (activities), diamonds (decisions), and ovals (start/end).
Functional process map	A process map showing detailed steps, activities, and relationships within a single function or department.
Functionality	How well the process performs its intended purpose.
FURPS model	A framework used to evaluate processes or systems based on Functionality, Usability, Reliability, Performance, and Supportability.
Future state map	A redesigned VSM representing the desired process after improvements have been implemented.
Future state modeling	Using data and process mapping to simulate the potential impact of improvements before implementation.
Gateway	A diamond-shaped decision point that splits or merges paths based on conditions or events.
Generative AI (Gen AI)	Artificial intelligence capable of generating new text, visuals, or designs to support process documentation, mapping, and idea generation.
Handoff	The transfer of work, information, or responsibility between roles, departments, or systems.
Impact versus effort matrix	A visual tool that categorizes improvement ideas by potential impact and implementation effort to prioritize actions.
Input	The data, materials, or information needed for a process to execute.
Intermediate event	An event that occurs during the process such as a message received, a timer, or an error.
Inventory	Materials or work-in-progress waiting between process steps; often a sign of imbalance or inefficiency.
Kano model	A customer satisfaction model that classifies features as Basic, Performance, or Delighters to guide which improvements most impact satisfaction.
Lane	A horizontal or vertical section in a swimlane diagram representing a participant (role, team, department, or system).
Lead time	The total time it takes for a product or service to move through an entire process, including both value-added and waiting time.
Lean methodology	A systematic approach that eliminates non-value-added activities ("waste") while maximizing value delivered to customers.
Lean thinking	A philosophy focused on maximizing customer value while minimizing waste by improving process flow and eliminating non-value-added activities.

MoSCoW method	A prioritization framework that classifies initiatives as Must Have, Should Have, Could Have, or Won't Have based on urgency and value.
Narrative step description	The text explaining "what happens" in each activity, who performs it, and what inputs/outputs are involved.
Non-value-added activity	Work that consumes time or resources but does not contribute to customer value.
Off-page connector	A process mapping symbol that indicates the continuation of a process on another page, labeled for reference.
Output	The product, service, or information produced by the process.
Parallel gateway	A point where multiple paths proceed simultaneously.
Performance	Speed, efficiency, and throughput of the process.
PESTLE analysis	A tool for examining external factors, Political, Economic, Social, Technological, Legal, and Environmental, that affect an organization's strategy.
Porter's five forces	A framework for analyzing the competitive forces within an industry: supplier power, buyer power, threat of new entrants, threat of substitutes, and competitive rivalry.
Predefined process (subprocess)	A process mapping symbol representing a standardized or reusable process defined elsewhere in documentation.
Process (in SIPOC)	The high-level steps that transform inputs into outputs—usually 4–7 steps.
Process automation	Using technology or software tools to perform repetitive or rules-based tasks with minimal human intervention, improving speed and accuracy.
Process boundary	The defined start and end points of a process used to avoid scope creep.
Process efficiency	The ratio of value-added time to total lead time, expressed as a percentage.
Process handbook	A catalog of an organization's core processes, interdependencies, and descriptions—serving as a "single source of truth."
Process improvement	A structured effort to identify inefficiencies, eliminate waste, and enhance performance in an existing workflow.
Process map	A visual representation of a process showing the sequence of steps, decision points, and flow of information or tasks.
Process mapping	The practice of visually documenting the steps, decisions, roles, and flows in a business process to understand and improve it.
Process model	A visual representation of how work is performed in an organization, often showing inputs, outputs, roles, and decision points.
Process narrative	A written description that explains each step of a process map, providing context, roles, tools, triggers, and notes.
Process optimization	Refining and adjusting an improved process to reach peak efficiency, quality, and cost-effectiveness through data analysis and redesign.
Process reengineering	A radical redesign of a process from the ground up to achieve major improvements in cost, quality, service, or speed.
Process reliability	The probability that a process performs correctly without failure over a specific time period; often measured through uptime or consistency.
Process trigger	The event or condition that starts a process or subprocess.
Reliability	Consistency and accuracy of process outcomes.
Requirements traceability matrix (RTM)	A tool linking business requirements to specific improvements, owners, measures, and validation criteria to maintain alignment.
Risk matrix	A grid used to evaluate risks by plotting likelihood versus impact, helping prioritize which risks require attention.
Root cause	The underlying issue that drives process problems, surfaced through mapping, narratives, or FURPS analysis.
Root cause analysis (RCA)	A structured process for identifying the true cause(s) of a problem to prevent recurrence.
Scenario	A narrative or example describing how a process or system operates under specific conditions; often used to identify challenges and define a desired "To-Be" state.
Sequence flow	Arrows in a process map or BPMN diagram that show the order of activities.
SIPOC diagram	A high-level mapping tool summarizing Suppliers, Inputs, Process, Outputs, and Customers of an end-to-end process.
Six sigma	A data-driven methodology that reduces process variation and defects to improve consistency and quality.
SMART goal	A goal-setting framework ensuring that objectives are Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant, and Time-bound.
Stakeholder	Any individual or group affected by, or with an interest in, a process, project, or system.
Standard work	Documented, repeatable best practices that define the most efficient way to complete a process consistently.
Start event	A BPMN symbol indicating where a process begins.
Statistical process control (SPC)	The use of control charts and data to monitor process performance and stability over time.
Strategy analysis	A business analysis area focused on defining strategic goals, assessing current capabilities, and recommending initiatives to achieve desired outcomes.
Sub-optimization	When one part of a system improves at the expense of the overall performance of the system.
Subprocess	A group of related activities collapsed into a single element to simplify complex process diagrams.
Supplier	The individual, system, or organization providing inputs to a process.
Supportability	Ability to monitor, sustain, and improve the process over time (dashboards, documentation, and metrics).
Sustaining the gain	The practice of maintaining improvements over time by embedding controls, monitoring, and reinforcement into daily operations.
Swimlane diagram	A type of process map that divides steps into lanes representing roles, departments, or systems to show responsibility and handoffs.
System reliability (multiplicative)	The combined reliability of sequential processes, calculated by multiplying individual process uptimes.
Systems thinking	A holistic approach that views processes as interdependent parts of a larger system, focusing on how changes in one area affect the whole.
Throughput	The total output or units completed within a specific period of time.
To-be process	A model representing how a process is intended to function after improvements or changes have been implemented.
Uptime	The percentage of time a process, system, or machine is available for use and functioning correctly.
Usability	How easy the process is to execute, including systems, interfaces, and steps required.
Use case	A description of how a user (actor) interacts with a system to achieve a specific goal; outlines actions, system responses, and outcomes.
Validation	The process of reviewing a process model or diagram with stakeholders to ensure accuracy, completeness, and real-world alignment.
Value stream map (VSM)	A visual tool used to analyze and document the flow of materials and information from process start to finish, identifying value-added and non-value-added time.
Value-added activity	Work that directly contributes to meeting customer requirements or improving the product or service.
Version control	The practice of tracking revisions to process documentation and designating an owner responsible for updates.